

Colubrids

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Reptilia
ORDER	Squamata
SUBORDER	Serpentes
SUPERFAMILY	Colubroidea
FAMILY	Colubridae
SPECIES	About 4,000

Sometimes referred to as typical snakes, colubrids form by far the largest family of snakes, accounting for almost two-thirds of all species. Some authorities have argued that this group is really composed of several distinct families. Colubrids occur in all parts of the world except Antarctica. Measured in both numbers of species and individuals, they are the most numerous

snakes on all continents except Australia. Colubrids live in habitats ranging from freshwater lakes, coastal marshes, and estuarine swamps to rain forest and arid desert. Such variation in mode of life and habitat means that they have a wide range of sizes, shapes, and colorations. All the world's rear-fanged venomous snakes are colubrids.

Anatomy

Colubrids have several anatomical features in common. All species are without a functioning left lung and a back-limb (pelvic) girdle. They also lack a small bone in the lower jaw

known as the coronoid bone. These 3 characteristics separate colubrids from the more primitive blind snakes, thread snakes, and boas and pythons. Colubrids also differ from these groups in having a more flexible skull, with jaws that can be spread apart to accommodate large items of food. This is possible

because the 2 halves of the lower jaw are not connected to one another. With a small number of exceptions, colubrids have large, platelike scales covering their head; this differentiates them from boas, pythons, and most vipers. The arrangement of the head scales is usually consistent within a species and can therefore be a useful feature for identification.

Venom

Some colubrids, notably ratsnakes, kill prey by constriction. Although most colubrids lack venom, about a third of all species have a type of venom-producing apparatus known as Duvernoy's gland, which delivers venom to the base of enlarged fangs toward the back of the mouth. Most venomous colubrids have a single pair of fangs, although others have 2 or 3 pairs. The fangs create a wound, into which the venom runs by capillary action. Unlike some front-fanged snakes, colubrids have solid fangs, although the venom may travel along a groove that runs the length of the fang. Most rear-fanged snakes are of little danger to humans because their fangs are too far back to be brought into play unless they chew for a sustained period and because their venom is,

BURROWING ASPES

The burrowing asps are a group of snakes that have been placed in various families, including the Colubridae, sometimes regarded as forming a separate group, the Atractaspididae, which consists of about 62 species. All except one species are found in Africa. These tunneling snakes feed mainly on amphisbaenians. Some have unique fangs that hinge sideways so that the snake can expose them without opening its mouth, injecting its venom with a sideways strike of the head.

in any case, weak. A few species, however, notably the boomslang and twig snakes, are dangerous and have caused human fatalities.

Reproduction

Colubrids lay eggs or give birth to live young. In those species that lay eggs, clutch size varies from one to 100 eggs. They are laid in holes or tunnels or under rotting leaves. The young may be similar to the parents but some species have distinctive juvenile coloration and markings.



HUNTING

Compared with many front-fanged snakes, the venomous colubrids have relatively weak venom and inefficient fangs with which to deliver it. Possibly because of this, some colubrids, such as the ratsnake, kill their prey by constriction, causing suffocation. This Everglades ratsnake has caught a barking treefrog. Once the victim is dead, the ratsnake will maneuver its body until the frog's head is in position for it to be swallowed.